The frequency of drone attacks in Pakistan had dropped to 64 in 2011 compared to 117 in 2010.[3] According to some analysts, this dip in the drone campaign was due to the decreasing number of Al Qaeda leaders and a pause in strikes in 2010 after the arrest of Raymond Davis, a CIA security contractor who killed two Pakistanis in Lahore, the US marines' attack on Abbottabad to kill Osama bin Laden and finally the US/NATO air strike on Pakistani checkposts in November 2011 (*Dawn*, 2012).

But after two months of lull in the drone attacks, it was observed that the Al Qaeda, TTP militants and other militant groups started regrouping and intensified their attacks.

According to a report by *New York Times*, the US and Pakistani officials confirmed that the two-month break in drone strikes in Pakistan helped embolden Al Qaeda and several Pakistani militant factions to regroup, increase attacks on Pakistani security forces and threaten intensified strikes against allied forces in Afghanistan (Dawn, 9 January 2012).

On realising this, the US started the drone campaign again on 10 January 2012 after a lull of 55 days. The previous strike had taken place on 16 November 2011. This pause was the longest since the programme was ramped up at the end of July 2008. In this strike, two missiles were fired at a vehicle in the village of Dogga near Miramshah, North Waziristan, resulting in the death of six alleged militants, including foreigners, purportedly Al Qaeda militants (Roggio, 2012).

> US officials told *The Long War Journal* on Dec. 12, 2011 that the program was put 'on hold' due to tensions over the Mohmand incident, but that they would strike again if a high value terrorist target that could not be ignored was spotted (Roggio, 2012).

Some argued that it had not stopped because of strained Pak-US relations. Rather it was a logistic problem as the US had to dismantle its system from Shamsi Airfield, therefore it took time to reinstall it at Bagram and restart the drone attacks.

Once back in the saddle, more drone attacks were launched on 12, 15, 19 and 23 January 2012, in which about 15 persons, including Arab fighters, were killed. Al Qaeda's external operational commander, Aslam Awan, was killed on 19 January. It was rumoured that Hakimullah Mehsud, TTP Chief, was reportedly killed on 15 January 2012, but